In Step

Our December 2026 link — what changes for you, in plain English

A proposal for discussion · CEA link · 26 weeks · code IS-26-T4

The short version

Five things to take away if you remember nothing else

35h	5	14	9 of 15	30 min
the contracted week, as now	**most days in a row**	**full weekends off a year**	**shift times you already work**	**off every closing shift**
no extra hours	up to 7 · today 7–9	today 10 · 7 in 26	6 new ones	up to 1 hour

Same hours, shorter closers, weekends off never more than five weeks apart, and never more than five days in a row, cover weeks aside.

Why the link has to change

Nobody is changing it for the sake of it

A new timetable in December 2026

More trains, at new times — the link has to follow them.

More of us on the link

It grows from 20 weeks to 26, so six more colleagues join it.

New staffing levels

At least 10 on a Sunday, and more at the close and at 22:00. We also aim for 14 on a Saturday.

The ticket office in fixed pairs

Two early and two late, on the same shifts, every day.

The change is coming whatever we do — the question is which version we want.

Will I work more?

The first thing everyone asks

	Today	In Step
Contracted hours a week	35h	**35h**
Contracted days at work a week	4.20	**4.19**
Contracted days at work a year	219.0	**218.6**

No. The same 35-hour week on average; weeks run 25h 30m–41h 05m Monday to Saturday (today 25h 10m–43h 50m), and two more days a year are Saturdays.

Will my basic pay change?

Basic pay follows your contracted hours

	Today	In Step
Contracted hours a week	35h	**35h**
Saturdays a year, at time and a quarter	26	**28**
Sunday overtime to share — each, a year	21	**20**
Swapping an early for a late, on average	32 min longer	**11 min shorter**
Finishing at 13:35 or 13:45 — each, a year	26	**12**

No: basic pay stays the same. Premium and overtime pay come to about £250 a year less, gross, if you work your share of Sundays. That assumes no swap overtime.

Will my shifts be longer?

Closing shifts get shorter, earlies longer — the average goes up about two minutes

	Today	In Step
Weekday closer — starts 15:45, not 15:15	8h 40m	**8h 10m**
Saturday closer — starts 15:45, not 14:45	9h 10m	**8h 10m**
Sunday closer — starts 15:15, not 14:30	8h 55m	**8h 10m**
Average early, Monday to Saturday	7h 59m	**8h 21m**
Average late, Monday to Saturday	8h 29m	**8h 10m**
Average shift, Monday to Saturday	8h 14m	**8h 16m**

Every closing shift is 30 to 60 minutes shorter; the longest early Monday to Saturday goes from 8h 30m to 8h 55m, and nothing runs over 9 hours.

Will I finish late more often?

3 more a year at 23:00 or later (42, today 39); 16 more at 22:00 or later (94, today 78)

	Today	In Step
Finishing at 23:00 or later — each, a year	39	**42**
Finishing at 22:00 or later — each, a year	78	**94**
Starting at 06:20 — each, a year	62	**60**
Shortest gap between two shifts	12h 30m	**14h 35m**

More people stay on after 22:00 under the December staffing; the three more at 23:00 or later are the fewest the rules allow.

Will I know the times?

15 shift times in all — 9 of them you already work

You work these today (9)

06:20–13:35
06:20–13:45
06:20–14:20
06:20–14:50
07:15–15:45
08:00–16:30
12:00–20:00
14:00–22:30
14:30–22:00

New times (6)

- Closers start later: 30 minutes on weekdays, an hour on Saturdays, 45 minutes on Sundays
- Two longer weekday earlies, 06:20–15:15 and 07:00–15:45, and a new late, 14:30–22:30
- On Sundays: a 9-hour early, 09:00–18:00, and the ticket-office late, 14:30–22:30

Fewer shift times than today (15, not 18) — and on a Saturday only the closer is new.

Rest and weekends

The biggest improvement over today

	Today	In Step
Full weekends off, about a year	10	**14**
Most days worked in a row	7 (up to 9)	**5 (up to 7)**
Rest-day breaks of two days or more	13 of 17	**22 of 26**
Shortest gap between two shifts	12h 30m	**14h 35m**
Weeks on one shift time, Monday to Friday	7 of 16	**18 of 21**

14 full weekends off a year, at most five weeks apart, and never more than five days in a row, cover weeks aside.

Your 26 weeks at a glance

The green bars are the full weekends off; where you start is decided later



Blocks of earlies or lates up to 5 weeks, 7 if the cover weeks go the same way; a full weekend off comes round at least every 5 weeks.

Booking leave

What 14 days of annual leave buys you, with Sundays off

	Today	In Step
Days off in a row — best place to book	30	**28**
Days off in a row — on average	23.4	**23.4**
Days off in a row — worst place	19	**20**
Leave for four full weeks off, at best	14	**15**

Best stretch 28 days, not 30; four full weeks off in a row, Sunday to Saturday, costs 15 days' leave, not 14. Average the same, worst a day better.

More staff on the floor

More people rostered every day, and more at the open and the close on most days

	Today	In Step
On duty on a weekday	11–12	**15**
On duty on a Saturday / Sunday	10 / 8	**14 / 10**
Fewest rostered on the floor	2	**3**
Avoidable fatigue warnings, cover weeks aside	4 (up to 5)	**0 (up to 1)**

At least three rostered on the floor, and no avoidable fatigue warnings, cover weeks aside.

The honest trade-offs

Nothing is free — here is what it costs

Six new shift times to learn

Three shorter lates, two longer weekday earlies and the 9-hour Sunday early.

Earlies or lates in longer runs

Up to 5 weeks of one kind, 7 if the cover weeks go the same way (today 2, up to 3).

Four weeks off: 15 days' leave, not 14

The least leave for four complete weeks off in a row, Sunday to Saturday.

Two more Saturdays a year

28 a year each, today 26 — fourteen on a Saturday, shared across 26 lines.

More late finishes

42 a year each at 23:00 or later (today 39), and 94 at 22:00 or later (today 78).

Fewer early finishes

12 a year each finish before 14:00 (today 26).

None of these is hidden: every figure here is worked out from the rota.

At a glance

Same hours and days, shorter closers, more weekends off, fewer days in a row

	Today	In Step
Contracted hours a week	35h	35h
Contracted days at work a year	219.0	218.6
Average shift · longest shift	8h 14m · 9h 10m	8h 16m · 9h 00m
Closing shift: weekday · Saturday · Sunday	8h 40m · 9h 10m · 8h 55m	**8h 10m · 8h 10m · 8h 10m**
Full weekends off, about a year	10	**14**
Most days worked in a row	7 (up to 9)	**5 (up to 7)**
Shortest gap between two shifts	12h 30m	14h 35m
Different shift times	18	15 (9 you know)
On duty weekday · Saturday · Sunday	11–12 · 10 · 8	15 · 14 · 10
Avoidable fatigue warnings, cover weeks aside	4 (up to 5)	0 (up to 1)

The costs: more late finishes and longer runs of earlies or lates.



What happens next

1. Look at the full proposal sheet — page 3 shows every week of the link
2. Tell us what worries you, even if it is small
3. Your feedback goes to the managers with the proposal